

Chapter 52-1

Liang Shi stood in place, drinking from the water that the staff had handed her. Qi Taitai¹ had already stepped over on her high heels.

Ten-centimeter green strappy high heels polished to a shine, perfectly matching the qipao² she wore.

She seemed particularly fond of wearing qipaos. Every time Liang Shi had seen her, she was dressed in a qipao.

Including in that memory.

She walked neither hurriedly nor slowly, each step swaying gracefully, like a lotus blooming in a river, swaying in the wind.

Without a doubt, she was very beautiful, well-maintained, and had a figure perfectly suited for qipaos.

But for Liang Shi, her very existence was oppressive.

Before she had even approached, Liang Shi could feel her heart pounding wildly in her chest, her mind filled with desperate thoughts of escape.

And the collision of high heels against the marble floor, click-clack, click-clack.

Could overlap perfectly with her memories.

Before she had even reached her, Liang Shi was already breaking out in cold sweat.

Liang Shi tried to convince herself in her heart: don't be afraid, there's nothing to fear, you've grown up now, she can't do anything to you.

But the fear emanating from deep within made her unable to stop shivering.

Zhao Ying also sensed something was wrong. As an actress, observing life and people was basic training.

Almost at a glance, she could tell there was something between Liang Shi and this investor's wife.

Zhao Ying stood up and walked to Liang Shi's side without hesitation, patting her arm, "Are you done filming?"

Only then did Liang Shi come back to her senses, gently exhaling, but when she tried to speak, she found her lips were still trembling.

This was a fear buried deep in her soul.

People say that an unfortunate childhood takes a lifetime to heal.

If it was a childhood of brutal abuse, then perhaps it could never be healed in a lifetime.

This kind of pain was embedded in the bones, something that could never be forgotten, occasionally emerging from the depths of memory to torment you, making you feel despair.

Liang Shi felt exactly like this now.

The moment she saw Qi Taitai, she couldn't help but tremble, shake, and want to flee.

Perhaps she wasn't as brave as she had been when encouraging Qi Jiao.

In this instant, she seemed to truly understand Qi Jiao.

Just like how the original body couldn't break free from Qiu Zimin's shackles, drifting like a wandering soul in the dark world Qiu Zimin had created for her.

Qi Jiao had lived under Qi Taitai's shadow from childhood to adulthood—how could she possibly muster the courage to resist?

This was completely unrealistic.

Fortunately, Zhao Ying was there. Her rationality returned somewhat, and she wasn't as afraid.

Liang Shi nodded in response to Zhao Ying: "Mm, I'm done."

Zhao Ying said: "Are you free later? I'll treat you to dinner."

Liang Shi immediately replied: "I'm free, but let me treat you instead."

If it weren't for Zhao Ying, she wouldn't have gotten the ticket to this role.

Just as her words fell, she heard a voice like opera singing: "I wonder if you'd mind adding me?"

It was Qi Taitai.

She always spoke in this tone. Liang Shi had once speculated about her profession.

But after searching for a lot of information online, she found nothing.

CEO Qi of Qida Company protected his wife and daughter's information extremely well—there was no information about them online.

She didn't even know the woman's name.

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned, "We..."

She was about to refuse, but the director came over and immediately said: "Of course we don't mind. It's our honor that Qi Taitai is willing to have dinner with us."

Liang Shi's refusal was right on her lips—she couldn't swallow it, but she couldn't say it either.

But Zhao Ying was much more straightforward than her, laughing: "Then Director, you can eat with Qi Taitai. I'm taking Liang Shi out to eat. My cousin is there too, and she has social anxiety—she can't meet so many people."

Zhao Ying directly used Zhao Xuning as a shield.

And with a completely fabricated reason at that.

Footnotes: ¹ Qi Taitai: "Taitai" is a respectful form of address for a married woman, often used for the wife of someone important or wealthy ² Qipao: A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by its form-fitting silhouette and high collar

Chapter 52-2

Liang Shi felt relieved in her heart.

The director's face fell upon hearing this. Anyone could see that Qi Taitai wanted to have dinner with Liang Shi, but now asking him to accompany her instead—wouldn't that be slighting Qi Taitai?

This was the wife of their drama's biggest investor!

If they offended her and the funding didn't come through, how could they continue filming?

All the preliminary preparation work would probably go to waste.

The director absolutely couldn't let this happen, but he didn't dare make things difficult for Zhao Ying either. After all, everyone knew Zhao Ying's family background wasn't simple—the Zhao family alone was enough to give him trouble.

After thinking it over, the easiest person to bully here was Liang Shi.

A newcomer with no distinguished family background. From her plain clothes and the car she drove, she was clearly different from someone like Zhao Ying, a wealthy young lady who had smooth sailing all her life.

The director, shrewd as he was, quickly figured all this out and immediately continued along with Zhao Ying's words: "Then you can eat with your cousin! I'll get to know Liang Shi better—after all, we'll be filming together later."

"There's plenty of time to get acquainted later, isn't there?" Zhao Ying firmly protected Liang Shi. "We already made plans today, and my cousin has a bad temper—she'll explode if she gets stood up."

Zhao Ying's cousin—that would be a Zhao family young lady.

Naturally someone the director couldn't afford to offend either.

Zhao Ying had calculated this point precisely.

In this circle, did the Zhao family need to fear the wife of some Qida¹ company?

Even if CEO Qi himself came, he'd have to politely greet Zhao Xuning.

CEO Qi's business empire was large, but not large enough to be untouchable.

It was still far from reaching the status of Haizhou's² two prominent families.

It was at most on par with the Zhao family.

Zhao Ying still had to work in the entertainment industry and didn't want any bad reputation, so she frantically used Zhao Xuning's "tiger skin"³ as protection.

Qi Taitai glanced at Zhao Ying, her crimson lips curving upward: "You're Zhao Ying?"

Zhao Ying nodded: "Hello."

"Zhao Yulin's daughter?" Qi Taitai's voice was gentle, just like a kind elder making small talk with you.

Zhao Ying nodded again: "Zhao Yulin is my mother. Do you know each other?"

Qi Taitai smiled: "We're acquainted. We've played mahjong together."

Zhao Ying: "..."

Bringing this up made Zhao Ying unhappy. She said coldly: "My mother stopped playing mahjong ten years ago."

Qi Taitai didn't show any displeasure at her rudeness, instead continuing to smile: "Yes, that's why I said we used to play mahjong together."

Zhao Ying: "...Oh."

Everyone knew her mother had once been severely addicted to mahjong, nearly losing the family business because of it.

It was her uncle's family—Zhao Xuning's family—who had bailed them out once.

Otherwise, their family would have fallen apart because of that addiction.

As someone who had experienced all of this, Zhao Ying naturally couldn't have a good attitude toward her mother's mahjong partners.

However, Qi Taitai's target wasn't her—she was just making casual conversation.

After the small talk, she turned her gaze to Liang Shi. Those eyes rippled like water, full of charm even without speaking. But the moment Liang Shi met her gaze, she felt that cold intent.

Hidden in the depths of her eyes were many emotions Liang Shi couldn't understand.

Liang Shi shuddered but also pinched her own leg where others couldn't see, forcing herself to calm down.

She couldn't always rely on Zhao Ying's protection.

Zhao Ying had already helped her a lot.

So even though Liang Shi was afraid, she firmly met Qi Taitai's gaze, feigning composure.

Qi Taitai looked at her, paused, then said: "I heard you had a falling out with your mother?"

An attitude of an elder lecturing a junior.

Hearing this, Liang Shi's brow furrowed tightly. After a moment, she replied: "What business is it of yours?"

Everyone: "..."

Footnotes: ¹ Qida: The name of CEO Qi's company ² Haizhou: The city where the story takes place ³

Tiger skin: Chinese idiom meaning to use someone else's authority or reputation for protection

Chapter 52-3

Everyone present collectively gasped.

The director was frantic, frantically giving Liang Shi meaningful looks, nearly blinking his eyes to pieces.

But Liang Shi remained unmoved.

Liang Shi carefully recalled the original body's former "aggressive" attitude and the unruly, unreasonable images from film and television works.

She acted out seven parts of it.

"It's been a while since we last met." Qi Taitai just smiled warmly. "Your temper has really grown."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow: "Has it? Not bad."

Her tone was flat, yet revealed a few traces of rebellious defiance.

Qi Taitai didn't mind her rudeness either, just stared intently at her. After a while, she suddenly said: "The styling photos you took today are very beautiful. The director says you have great acting talent."

Liang Shi: "..."

That phrase "what business is it of yours" was stuck in her throat. Considering so many people present and the director's reputation, she restrained herself, but still replied uncooperatively: "Not bad."

Zhao Ying tugged at Liang Shi's arm and spoke up at the right moment: "Sorry, our filming is finished and we're planning to leave now. My cousin is already messaging to hurry us up. Really sorry. Auntie, if you want to arrange dinner, let's do it next time."

Qi Taitai looked at Zhao Ying and asked gently: "You two seem to have a very good relationship."

Zhao Ying answered without thinking: "This is my cousin's friend, and I'm her senior, so naturally I have to take care of her more."

"That's nice." Qi Taitai said: "I wouldn't have expected Liang Shi to have so many friends."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Why did this sound so strange?

But with so many people around, Liang Shi was too lazy to ask.

She discovered that the fear in her heart could also be gradually overcome. Probably because Zhao Ying was beside her supporting her, giving her a sense of belonging and security.

She wasn't as afraid of Qi Taitai as she had been initially.

"Liang Shi, come here." Qi Taitai called her. "I have a few words I'd like to say to you."

Liang Shi frowned. Just as she was hesitating, Zhao Ying said quietly: "Don't go."

Then Zhao Ying asked Qi Taitai: "What can't be said openly? Auntie, you're treating me like an outsider here."

"Just some private matters." Qi Taitai looked at her. "I want to ask her about some things regarding my daughter. It wouldn't be convenient for you to hear this."

Zhao Ying: "..."

Qi Taitai continued: "You've known her for a short time, so you probably don't know that my daughter was also one of her good friends. Back then, they were very close—she would often cling to my daughter calling her 'sister.' Never mind."

Qi Taitai put away that reminiscent expression and said gently: "It seems you don't know about this either."

After saying this, she looked at Liang Shi again: "Little friend¹, will you come over?"

—Little friend.

That term she used to call her.

Liang Shi instantly got goosebumps all over.

—Little friend, are you being disobedient?

—Jiao Jiao, bring that little friend over here.

—Little friend, only if you're good can you go home.

...

Liang Shi looked at her, seeming to read what was hidden in the depths of her gaze.

It was despair and gloom intertwined with madness.

She closed her eyes, steadying herself with a hand on Zhao Ying's arm.

Zhao Ying could see her reluctance and immediately advised: "Don't go."

But Liang Shi shook her head. She would have to face this eventually.

What she was facing now wasn't just Qi Taitai, but the deepest fear in her own heart.

"It's okay, Sister Ying." Liang Shi comforted her, then strode forward.

The photography studio had a rest room. Qi Taitai and Liang Shi walked in one after the other.

Everyone was confused.

The director approached Zhao Ying: "What's Liang Shi's background?"

"I don't know." Zhao Ying said: "If you want to know, go ask her yourself."

The director who got rebuffed: "..."

Footnotes: ¹ Little friend: A term of address that can be condescending when used by adults toward other adults, often implying the person is childish or naive

Chapter 52-4

//

Inside the rest room, it was very quiet. The air humidifier on the makeup table was still working, spraying fine mist.

Qi Taitai stood there with her arms crossed, carefully examining Liang Shi. "You've indeed grown up."

Liang Shi's tone was unfriendly: "If you have something to say, say it. If not, I'm leaving."

She was using coldness to disguise herself, acting half-真 and half-fake.

"Did you go find Qi Jiao?" Qi Taitai finally steered the conversation to the main topic. "What did you want with Qi Jiao? Was it to reminisce about old times?"

Liang Shi frowned: "Are you stalking Qi Jiao?"

"Do I need to stalk my own daughter?" Qi Taitai laughed lightly. "Qi Jiao is very obedient. She never hides anything from me."

"Oh." Liang Shi stopped being evasive. "I did go find Qi Jiao, and Qi Jiao should have told you what I went there for. I went to find her to look for a child from her class. It was just coincidental that she happened to be that class's teacher."

Qi Taitai looked at her, her tone slightly rising: "Is that so?"

Liang Shi: "Believe it or not."

Qi Taitai tucked a strand of fallen hair behind her ear, her movements full of charm.

But no one was there to appreciate it.

Her voice became deeper: "Little friend, you're really not obedient now."

"So what?" Liang Shi looked at her, her eyes containing fierceness. "What do you want to do? Lock me in a little dark room? Have your daughter force me to speak? Or use a rattan cane to whip me? Qi Taitai, I've grown up."

For a moment, Qi Taitai was also frightened by her gaze.

But she quickly readjusted: "No wonder your mother says you're smart—you still remember things that happened when you were so small. Our Jiao Jiao has probably forgotten by now."

"It has nothing to do with me." Liang Shi became even more distant. The strong walls she had built with her forceful attitude became even more solid. "If you called me here just to say this nonsense, then I won't keep you company."

"Little friend, you're still the same as when you were little." Qi Taitai laughed lightly. "So impatient. Can't you listen to what adults have to say?"

"Sorry." Liang Shi said: "I'm the adult now."

Qi Taitai's expression changed slightly.

Liang Shi continued: "You're no longer an adult. Twenty years have passed—you're already an old person now. Don't try to threaten me in that way anymore. If I ever find audio or video evidence someday, I'll send you to prison. Child abuse—even if it's been over twenty years, even if the law doesn't prosecute, I'll still make you lose all reputation."

"So where's your audio and video evidence?" Qi Taitai sneered. "Liang Shi, you're getting more and more naive."

"What if someday Heaven sees you've done too much evil and just delivers that evidence right to me?" Liang Shi said: "This world has karmic retribution¹. Do you believe it?"

After hearing this, Qi Taitai's eyes flashed with uncontrollable malice. She frowned and asked viciously: "Then why haven't the evildoers died yet?"

"They will eventually." Liang Shi said: "People act, Heaven watches²."

Qi Taitai laughed coldly: "Naive."

But a moment later, she returned to her previous demeanor.

She looked at Liang Shi with a nostalgic expression: "You look really good now, and you believe in justice and righteousness, and you've married a wife. By the way, is your wife pregnant?"

Liang Shi frowned: "What does it have to do with you?"

Qi Taitai said: "Just asking casually."

She stared intently at Liang Shi, as if looking at someone else through her. Her tone was full of nostalgia and attachment: "If my Jiao Jiao could see how you look now, she'd probably be very happy."

Liang Shi: "..."

Didn't Qi Jiao already see her?

She didn't understand what Qi Taitai meant.

Obviously, Qi Taitai didn't intend for her to understand—she was just venting her own emotions.

After venting, Qi Taitai became cold again: "Liang Shi, I don't care what you want to do, but don't bother Qi Jiao anymore. What my daughter wants to do is naturally not for you to manage."

She said word by word: "Mind your own business."

Liang Shi looked at her like this, seeming to find her vulnerable point.

Even someone as strong as her was just pretending.

So Liang Shi overcame the fear in her heart and confronted her forcefully: "What if I refuse?"

Qi Taitai closed her eyes. When she opened them again, a sharp light flashed through: "If you make me lose this daughter again, I will kill you."

//

Qi Taitai was like a gust of wind—she came quickly and left quickly too.

After she left, Liang Shi went to eat with Zhao Ying.

Originally they were supposed to meet Zhao Xuning, but Zhao Xuning was swamped at the hospital and couldn't come.

Zhao Ying didn't ask about what happened between her and Qi Taitai, but provided some information instead.

While they were talking in the rest room, Zhao Ying had called her dear mother and managed to extract some information about Qi Taitai.

Qi Taitai's name was Yang Jiani. She had originally been among Haizhou's wealthy elite, but when the Yang family got involved in a bribery case, they were directly investigated and fell from grace. Yang Jiani then married her high school classmate Qi Xiangui, who was now CEO Qi of Qida Company, becoming Qi Taitai.

While Qi Xiangui always maintained the public image of doting on his wife and daughter, he wasn't good to his family.

Qi Xiangui had a problem—he loved drinking, and when he drank too much, he would throw things.

Zhao Ying's mother had previously played mahjong at the Qi house and had seen Qi Xiangui drunk. He would ramble on endlessly, and later even flipped their mahjong table.

Yang Jiani had originally studied opera. She had loved it since childhood, but after marrying Qi Xiangui, he didn't like her showing her face in public, so she gave up her career.

However, she always wore qipaos, regardless of the occasion.

She wore qipaos with exceptional grace too.

Over time, people would actually avoid her, not wanting to clash with her style.

"What about her attitude toward her daughter?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Ying said: "She's especially good to her daughter. My mother said compared to her, I'm like I was picked up from somewhere."

According to Zhao Yulin, Yang Jiani's most beloved was her daughter. She would give her whatever she wanted, even kneeling down to wipe her daughter's shoes and put them on for her, loving her to the bone.

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned.

She kept thinking about Yang Jiani's final words, always feeling there was something suspicious about them.

That evening when she saw Xu Qingzhu, the two discussed it. Xu Qingzhu frowned and said: "Repeat what she said again."

Liang Shi relied on her good memory to repeat: "If you make me lose this daughter again, I will kill you."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes widened, and she and Liang Shi said simultaneously: "Again?"

—Yes, again.

As everyone knew, Qi Xiangui and Yang Jiani had only ever had one daughter from beginning to end, and that was Qi Jiao.

But Qi Jiao was still alive.

So who was the daughter who had died?

Footnotes: ¹ Karmic retribution: The Buddhist/Taoist concept that good and evil deeds will eventually be repaid in kind ² People act, Heaven watches: A Chinese idiom meaning that even if people think no one sees their actions, Heaven (or cosmic justice) is always watching